The Tipping Table

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 4

The wagon rested beneath the ridge shelter. Its small sail was folded, its wheels were chocked, and its sand sack sat low beside the explorer case. Inside the case lay your original map and the first missing section. Three spaces still waited to be filled.

Something tapped beneath the shelter roof. Nib put one paw on a little timber table. The far corner rose. When he lifted his paw, it dropped with another tap.

“An excellent table, apart from its standing-up,” Nib observed thoughtfully.

Through a small opening above the drawer, Lark could see a folded piece of explorer paper. She tried the handle. The drawer moved a tiny way, then caught.

Nib rolled an apple beneath the short leg. The apple rolled out again.

“A delicious table leg,” Nib murmured doubtfully. “Very poor at staying.”

Lark held the frame steady. On a repair shelf behind her lay several flat wooden offcuts. Beneath the picnic basket was your rolled mat. There were useful things here, if they could work out what to do first.

Lark opened the journal to yesterday's curving letter.

“Here is our soft hiss,” Lark invited gently. “Find s beside m. You can hear either sound again if you want.”

The table answered with a little tap. Lark drew a tall line on the empty page and crossed it near the top.

“This is lowercase t,” Lark explained clearly. “Put your tongue just behind your top teeth. Release a tiny tap of air: /t/. It stops quickly. We won't add an extra vowel. Listen, then find t.”

Nib tried the sound. His goggles slipped. He pushed them up without touching the table.

“A very small sound for a very talkative table,” Nib whispered suspiciously.

Lark set a beside t. She joined their sounds slowly into at. Then she put m at the beginning: m, a, t. Mat.

“Our mat could help,” Lark suggested hopefully. “Read at with me. Now join all three sounds in mat.”

Nib fetched the rolled mat and spread it on the shelter floor. Its corner was soft enough to fold, but firm enough to hold its shape.

Before they used it, Lark left room beside its label in the journal.

“Write t here,” Lark invited warmly. “Down from the top, then a short line across. You can follow my first mark or make your own beside it.”

Nib folded one edge of the mat into a small pad. Lark kept her wing against the tabletop. The gap beneath the short leg remained plainly visible.

“We need to fill that gap before pulling the drawer,” Lark explained calmly. “Put the folded edge beneath the short leg. I'll keep holding the table.”

The pad fitted. Nib pressed one corner of the table, then the other. Both stayed level. This time, when he pulled the drawer, it slid out with a gentle wooden sigh.

Inside lay the second missing section of your map.

“Not even a wobble,” Nib whispered suspiciously. He tapped the tabletop once more, just to make sure.

Lark laid the new paper beside the original and the orchard section. Under the moonstone's amber light, hidden ink drew a route down toward the river. A little island shelter waited at its end. Two spaces remained empty.

A tiny sketch of the Treasure Tree stood in the margin. Its upper branch divided into a fork.

“That branch looks familiar,” Lark murmured thoughtfully. She copied it into the journal before packing the fragile paper.

Nib sat on the unfolded part of the mat. Lark made another word by replacing the first letter of mat with s. Sat.

“Mat. Sat,” Lark read softly. “The same ending, with a different beginning. Try sat with me.”

On your new journal page, she drew the short leg, the folded pad, and the open drawer.

“What let the drawer slide?” Lark asked gently. “Was it pulling harder, or supporting the short leg? You can use our picture to explain.”

Lark held the table while Nib exchanged the temporary mat pad for a flat offcut from the repair shelf. The table stayed steady. Your mat could come with you.

Outside, the first raindrop spotted the path. Nib looked from the cloud to the old map's fraying edge.

“An excellent time,” Nib remarked cautiously, “for paper to have a roof.”

The table was fixed, the second section was safe, and your next route led toward the river.